us get away unscathed. In such a situation the one who spotted the adversary first, had all the advantage. In this case not only were they unaware of us but we were also on higher ground and thus dominating the area. I had to make up my mind quickly. Ultimately, it was us or them! I took a calculated risk and decided that if the group moved up the hill towards us, we would open fire, and if not, we would wait and watch. There appeared to be no other option in that fog-covered and densely forested environment of the Patkai range.

Fortunately, they fell in and after checking their weapons and equipment in an orderly manner, started moving back. This was an indication that they were from the Burmese Army, and I heaved a sigh of relief. Had they moved towards us, it could have resulted in an unsavoury incident, a firefight with international ramifications, and probably the end of my military career! That incident would also have spelt doom for our CO as the buck would have stopped at his level, and consequently, a serious setback for our unit.

Even to this day I get the shivers when I recall the events of that dawn. I had a local guide whom I then despatched, with some rum and cigarettes, as my emissary to get some news of the gang. In fact, he actually followed the Burmese patrol till they reached their post. Waving a white handkerchief he approached them and handed over the gifts. He was then told by the Burmese that a large Naga gang had been chased across to our side the previous night. He thanked the Burmese post commander and returned posthaste to the place on the border where I was waiting for the news. Having got the vital information, we literally ran back to the Battalion HQ, believing we had ‘breaking news’. On reaching Anutangre, I briefed Lieutenant Colonel Awasthi on the map, and gave the news obtained from the Burmese Army. He appeared preoccupied and was not greatly enthused with the inputs I had brought. In fact, our troops had been informed by the villagers of the presence of jungle ‘manus’, a local terminology for the insurgents, and were already in contact with them at a few places. He told me to coordinate the ongoing operations and function as the adjutant.